CRISIS PLAYBOOK · NO. 05

WEEK OF 7 DECEMBER 2026

- T+00:00 Incident declared
- T+00:02 Alert sent · push, SMS, voice
- T+01:30 Escalated · no response
- T+04:10 Team acknowledged



HOSPITALITY

Ready for Martyn's Law.

Evacuate, invacuate, lock down and tell everyone on site, fast. A practical playbook for hotels, bars, pubs, restaurants and venues, written for the busiest weeks of the year.

T+00:00 · T+00:05 · T+00:15 · T+01:00 · T+04:00

INSIDE

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A practical playbook for hotels, pubs, bars, restaurants and venues: what Martyn's Law will require, how every shift protects guests and staff on the worst night, and how to be ready before the festive season peaks.

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FOREWORD

In a busy bar or hotel, the first minutes belong to the people on shift.

On the night of the London Bridge and Borough Market attack in June 2017, the attackers moved through a restaurant courtyard, bars and a restaurant on Stoney Street. The Chief Coroner found that all eight people who died did so within 15 minutes of the attack beginning.[1] In the City Room at Manchester Arena a few weeks earlier, a concern raised by a member of the public did not reach anyone who could act on it, partly because a radio channel was busy.[2]

Martyn's Law, the Terrorism (Protection of Premises) Act 2025, is named after Martyn Hett, one of the 22 people killed at Manchester Arena.[2,3] It received Royal Assent on 3 April 2025, and the Security Industry Authority expects it to come into force in spring 2027.[3,4] Pubs, bars, restaurants, cafés, hotels and nightclubs where 200 or more people can be expected at the same time will need procedures to evacuate, invacuate, lock down and communicate with everyone on site.[4,5,6]

This playbook is for the people who will make that work on a Saturday night in December: owners, general managers, duty managers, security leads and operations teams. It covers the law as enacted, the roles each shift needs, how to reach guests and staff in minutes, the other emergencies that are far more likely, and a dated plan. The companion intelligence report sets out the evidence in full.

The Crises Control team
Crises Control

INTRODUCTION

Three things protect people on the worst night.

Hospitality venues are busy, noisy, open late and staffed by people on different shifts, many of them new. The venues that cope best are not the ones with the thickest plan. They are the ones where every shift knows who decides, what to do and how to tell everyone fast.

One person decides

Every shift has a named duty manager who can declare an evacuation, invacuation or lockdown without waiting for permission, and everyone knows who that is tonight.

Everyone hears it at once

A code phrase, a radio call and an alert to every phone, so the kitchen, the bedrooms and the smoking area hear the same instruction within a minute.

Plans people actually know

Short procedures, briefed at induction and walked through on the late shift, not a binder in the office that nobody has opened.

A plan nobody on shift knows is not a plan.

The Manchester Arena Inquiry found that on the night, plans "were not known by everyone who should have known about them".[7] Martyn's Law asks hospitality to close that gap before the law starts, not after.

PART 01

Know the duty.

What the Act requires of hotels, bars, pubs, restaurants and venues, the four procedures, and a severity scale every shift can use.

01 What the law says, exactly

02 Four procedures for every venue

03 A hospitality severity ladder

KNOW THE DUTY

What Martyn's Law asks of hospitality

> **Count the busiest realistic night, not a quiet Tuesday.**

The Terrorism (Protection of Premises) Act 2025 received Royal Assent on 3 April 2025. The Home Office expects an implementation period of at least 24 months, and there is no legal requirement to comply until the duties come into force.[4] The SIA, which will regulate the Act, says it expects the Act to come into force in spring 2027 and will confirm the exact date ahead of time.[3]

The Act covers premises wholly or mainly used for purposes listed in Schedule 1. Statutory guidance says the "food and drink" use "includes bars, pubs, restaurants, cafés and food halls"; "hotels etc" also covers hostels and holiday parks; and nightclubs fall under entertainment and leisure.[6]

Premises are in the standard tier where 200 to 799 people, including staff, can reasonably be expected to be present at the same time from time to time, and in the enhanced tier at 800 or more.[4] Count the busiest realistic night, not a quiet Tuesday: a Christmas party, a New Year's Eve ticketed event or a wedding in the function suite.

Standard tier premises must notify the SIA and have, so far as is reasonably practicable, appropriate public protection procedures for evacuation, invacuation, lockdown and communication.[4,5] The Home Office says these are simple, low-cost steps that do not require physical alterations or new equipment.[4]

Enhanced tier premises must also have public protection measures covering monitoring, movement, physical safety and security, and the security of information; document compliance and give it to the SIA; and, where the responsible person is an organisation, designate a senior individual.[8]

Penalties reach £10,000 for standard duty premises, and £18m or 5% of worldwide revenue for enhanced duty premises.[9] Existing premises will have three months from commencement to notify the SIA, and changes must be notified within 28 days.[10]

FOUR PROCEDURES

Evacuate, invacuate, lock down, communicate

The Act's four public protection procedures, as the Home Office defines them, and what each means in a hotel, bar or restaurant.[5]

Evacuation

"Getting people away from danger by moving them out of the premises." Know every exit, including through the kitchen, and where guests go once they are out.[5]

Invacuation

"Moving people away from danger to a place within the premises." A function room, back corridor or cellar away from glass and the main doors.[5]

Lockdown

"Securing the premises to prevent individuals entering or leaving." Who locks which door, who drops the shutters, how fast, and on every shift.[5]

Communication

"Ensuring information is provided to individuals at the premises." Staff, guests, bedrooms, terraces, toilets, contractors and the next shift.[5]

> The Home Office's own example is a 400-seat restaurant: two evacuation routes, nominated staff who lock doors and close shutters on the shift manager's instruction, and a short briefing for every new starter at induction.[5]

SEVERITY

A hospitality severity ladder for every shift

Grade early and regrade often. If in doubt, go one level higher and step down later. The duty manager can declare any level.

SEV 1

Critical

TRIGGERS

An attack or credible threat at or next to the venue. A fire with people unaccounted for. A crowd crush or several casualties.

WHO IS ALERTED, HOW

Everyone on site, the on-call general manager, the head office crisis team and security leads. 999 first.

Code phrase · radio · PA · SMS · voice

SEV 2

Major

TRIGGERS

A full evacuation on a busy night. A suspicious item. A serious assault or suspected spiking needing hospital. Power lost in service. Booking or payment systems down across sites.

WHO IS ALERTED, HOW

Duty manager, general manager, area or operations manager, IT or facilities on call.

Radio · SMS · push · escalate after 10 min

SEV 3

Moderate

TRIGGERS

One site's tills or booking system failing. A guest collapse. An aggressive group removed. People trapped in a lift.

WHO IS ALERTED, HOW

Duty manager, general manager, service desk or facilities helpdesk.

Radio · push · email

SEV 4

Minor

TRIGGERS

Suspicious behaviour reported and resolved. A near miss. A single device fault. Verbal abuse logged.

WHO IS ALERTED, HOW

Duty manager, recorded for the weekly review and trend reporting.

App · email

PART 02

On the night.

The first hour of the worst night, the roles every shift needs, how to reach everyone, and the emergencies that are far more likely.

01 The first hour

02 Roles on every shift

03 Reaching guests and staff fast

04 Other emergencies

05 Messages ready to send

THE FIRST HOUR

Saturday, 22:15: an attack outside

Illustrative: a city-centre hotel with a bar and restaurant, around 550 people on site. Police instructions always come first.

CLOCK	ACTION	OWNER
T+00:00	**Door team sees people running from the street** Shouts of a knife attack nearby. The door supervisor radios the code phrase to the duty manager.	DOOR SUPERVISOR
T+00:01	**Lockdown and invacuation declared** Doors locked, shutters down, music off. Guests moved away from glass to the function room.	DUTY MANAGER
T+00:02	**999 called, log started** What, where, which direction, how many on site. Every decision from now is logged with a time.	RECEPTION
T+00:03	**Every member of staff alerted** Code phrase on the PA, radio and an alert to every phone. Staff reply when their area is safe.	DUTY MANAGER
T+00:06	**Guests in bedrooms told to stay put** Room phones and text: stay in your room, lock the door, keep away from windows.	NIGHT MANAGER
T+00:12	**Everyone accounted for, escalated** Chase staff who have not replied, including smokers and anyone outside. On-call general manager and head office alerted.	SHIFT MANAGERS
T+01:00	**Police briefed, people cared for** Floor plans and numbers to police. Guests and staff stay inside until police advise otherwise.	GENERAL MANAGER

ROLES

Who does what, on every shift

Name the people at the start of each shift. There is no statutory training requirement, but staff with a role in the procedures must know them and what they have to do.[5]

01 Duty manager: decides and declares

Has authority to call evacuation, invacuation or lockdown at once, and to call 999. Does not wait for head office.

02 Door and security team: first eyes

Spot and report early, lock doors, stop people entering, and give police clear information on arrival.

03 Bar and floor staff: move the room

Each person owns a section: move guests from glass and doors, sweep toilets and terraces, and report when clear.

04 Reception or night manager: the hotel

Calls 999, reaches guests in bedrooms and holds the guest list and today's function bookings.

05 Kitchen and back of house: the rear

Secure the back doors and delivery yard, cut gas if instructed, and know which rooms can be used as safe areas.

06 Communicator: who has heard

Sends the alert, tracks who has replied and chases the rest, and logs who was told what and when.

COMMUNICATION

Reaching guests and staff in minutes

Noise, music, bedrooms, outdoor areas and staff on breaks make hospitality hard to reach. Use more than one route, and confirm who has heard.

A code phrase everyone knows

A neutral phrase on the PA or radio that tells staff what is happening without alarming guests. Change it if it leaks.

Stop the music, light the room

Music off and house lights up so announcements can be heard, unless lockdown means lights off on police advice.

An alert to every phone

One message to staff on duty by SMS, push and voice, with a reply to confirm. Chase anyone who does not answer.

Guests you cannot see

Bedrooms, toilets, terraces, smoking areas and private dining rooms each need a named person or route.

People off site

The next shift, off-duty staff and families. Tell them not to come in, and keep updates on a schedule. Counter Terrorism Policing's public advice is RUN, HIDE, TELL.[11]

> **At Manchester Arena, a steward without a radio passed on a concern; a colleague with one tried to report it but someone else was talking, and it went no further.[2] Never rely on a single channel.**

OTHER EMERGENCIES

The emergencies that are far more likely

Terrorism is rare. Fire, medical emergencies, spiking, power and system failures are not. The same roles and alerts handle them all.

EMERGENCY	FIRST ACTION ON SITE	FIRST ACTION FOR MANAGERS
Fire alarm in a full venue	Evacuate by the plan. Sweep sections and bedrooms. Do not let guests collect coats or go back in.	Account for staff and guests from the booking and room lists. Meet the fire service with the plan.
Medical emergency	Call 999, send for the defibrillator and a first aider, clear space and send someone to guide the ambulance.	Look after witnesses and staff, record what happened and check first aid cover for the rest of the night.
Suspected spiking	Stay with the person, get help and call police or an ambulance if needed. Keep the drink if you can.	Report it, keep CCTV and brief door staff. Police received 6,732 reports in a year to April 2023.[12]
Power failure	Emergency lighting check, stop cooking, keep exits clear, and decide quickly whether to evacuate.	Call the supplier or facilities, plan for lifts, fridges, tills and door locks, and tell arriving guests.
Booking or payment systems down	Switch to the paper booking list and offline or cash procedure. Do not keep restarting terminals.	Find out whether it is an outage or an attack, and tell sites what still works. A 2022 cyber incident disrupted IHG's booking channels.[13]
Violence or disorder	Make safe, call 999 if anyone is in danger, and do not detain. Staff safety first.	Support the staff involved, keep CCTV and review staffing for the next nights.

MESSAGES

Six messages ready to send

Short, specific and calm. Fill the brackets, never guess the cause, and always say when the next update will come.

SMS · STAFF ON DUTY — 139 chars

> LOCKDOWN at [venue]. Move guests away from doors and glass to [area]. Doors stay locked. Do not go outside. Reply 1 when your area is safe.

Under 160 characters, so it arrives as one message.

SMS · HOTEL GUESTS — 144 chars

> [Hotel]: police are dealing with an incident nearby. Please stay in your room, lock the door and keep away from windows. Next update by [22:45].

Only to guests who have given a mobile number.

SMS · OFF-DUTY AND NEXT SHIFT — 131 chars

> [Venue] is closed tonight due to an incident nearby. Do not travel in. Everyone on site is being looked after. Next update [08:00].

EMAIL · GUESTS WITH BOOKINGS

> Because of an incident near [venue], we are closed this evening. Please do not travel to us. Your booking will be [moved or refunded] and we will contact you by [time].

Send from the booking system so it reaches tonight's and tomorrow's bookings.

EMAIL · SUPPLIERS AND BOOKING PLATFORMS

> Our booking and payment systems are offline while we investigate. Deliveries continue as booked. Do not act on any request to change bank details; call [known number].

Attackers often follow an outage with fake payment requests.

HOLDING LINE · MEDIA

> We are aware of an incident near [venue] this evening. Our priority is the safety of our guests and team, and we are following police advice. We will share more when we can.

PART 03

Ready for December.

What to do before the first Christmas party, three scenarios to rehearse, a dated plan, and the questions to ask.

01 Festive season readiness

02 Three scenarios

03 Week, month, quarter

04 Questions and checklist

FESTIVE READINESS

Six steps before the first Christmas party

The weeks to New Year bring the biggest crowds, the most new staff and the longest nights. Finish these now.

01 Count your peak nights

Work out how many people, including staff, can reasonably be expected on your busiest nights, function rooms and terraces included. It decides your tier.[4,6]

02 Name the duty manager for every night

Publish who decides on each shift until 2 January, with an on-call general manager behind them.

03 Brief every seasonal starter

A short induction on the four procedures and their role, as in the Home Office restaurant example.[5]

04 Walk through a lockdown

Ten minutes with the late shift: which doors lock, where guests go, who checks the toilets and terrace.

05 Load every contact, including agency staff

Mobile numbers for everyone on the rota, tested with a short alert that asks for a reply.

06 Plan for the outage

Paper booking lists, an offline payment or cash procedure and a known number for every supplier.

SCENARIOS

Three illustrative scenarios to rehearse

CITY-CENTRE BAR AND NIGHTCLUB, 900 CAPACITY

A fight spills inside, then reports of a weapon outside

THE TRIGGER

Door staff see a crowd running towards the entrance at 01:00.

WHAT HURTS

Music still playing and nobody sure who decides.

WHAT HELPS

A code phrase, doors that lock in seconds and staff who own sections.

REHEARSE

A five-minute lockdown drill before opening.

HOTEL, 140 BEDROOMS AND A FUNCTION SUITE

A fire alarm during a 300-guest Christmas party

THE TRIGGER

Smoke in the kitchen at 21:30 with the suite full and bedrooms occupied.

WHAT HURTS

Party guests returning for coats and drivers blocking the fire lane.

WHAT HELPS

Section sweeps, a guest list by room and a clear assembly point.

REHEARSE

A walk-through with the events team and night porter.

RESTAURANT GROUP, 12 SITES

Booking and payment systems fail on the last Saturday before Christmas

THE TRIGGER

Card terminals and the booking platform fail at 18:00 across all sites.

WHAT HURTS

Each manager calling IT separately and guests turned away at the door.

WHAT HELPS

Printed booking lists, a cash procedure and one acknowledged instruction to every site.

REHEARSE

One site running on paper for an hour.

YOUR PLAN

This week, this month, this quarter

Owners are suggestions. Adjust them to your structure, and date every action.

WHEN	ACTIONS	OWNER
This week	Name a duty manager for every night to New Year. Brief the four procedures and the code phrase at every shift start.	General manager
This week	Load every staff mobile, including agency and seasonal staff, and test an alert that asks for a reply.	Operations manager
This month	Count peak numbers for every site and room. Decide your likely tier and who the responsible person is.	Head of security, with legal
This month	Write one page per site: evacuation, invacuation, lockdown and communication. Walk through lockdown on a late shift.	General manager
This quarter	Prepare for SIA notification within three months of commencement. Enhanced tier: designate a senior individual and start the compliance document.	Chief operating officer
This quarter	Run a joint exercise with head office on an attack nearby and a system outage. Report gaps and dated fixes to the board.	Head of security

FOR LEADERS

Questions for your leadership team

Ask them out loud. Vague answers are the finding.

THE DUTY

- ? Which of our sites are likely to be standard tier, which enhanced, and who is the responsible person for each?
- ? Could every site evacuate, invacuate, lock down and communicate tonight, and when was it last practised?
- ? Who on tonight's rota can declare a lockdown without asking anyone?

THE PEOPLE

- ? How long would it take to reach every member of staff on duty, and to know who had not replied?
- ? How would we reach guests in bedrooms, on terraces and in private dining rooms?
- ? Are our seasonal and agency staff briefed to the same standard as the regulars?

CHECKLIST

Are you ready for Martyn's Law?

Tick what is true today. Anything blank is your next action.

- [ ] **Peak numbers counted for every site**
  Including staff, function rooms and outside areas.

- [ ] **Four procedures written for every site**
  Evacuation, invacuation, lockdown and communication.

- [ ] **A named duty manager on every shift**
  With authority to act at once.

- [ ] **Every staff member briefed on their role**
  Including seasonal, agency and night staff.

- [ ] **One alert reaches everyone on duty**
  With replies tracked and non-responders chased.

- [ ] **A way to reach guests in bedrooms**
  And in toilets, terraces and private rooms.

- [ ] **Outage procedures for bookings and payments**
  Tested on a real shift.

- [ ] **Ready to notify the SIA**
  And, for enhanced tier, a senior individual named.

GLOSSARY

Words worth knowing

Martyn's Law

The Terrorism (Protection of Premises) Act 2025, named after Martyn Hett, who was killed at Manchester Arena.

Responsible person

The person or organisation in control of qualifying premises for the use that brings them into scope.

Standard tier

Premises where 200 to 799 people, including staff, can reasonably be expected at the same time.

Enhanced tier

Premises where 800 or more people can reasonably be expected at the same time.

Public protection procedures

Actions staff can take if they suspect an attack: evacuation, invacuation, lockdown and communication.

Public protection measures

Wider enhanced tier measures on monitoring, movement, physical security and information security.

Invacuation

Moving people away from danger to a safer place inside the premises.

Lockdown

Securing the premises to stop people entering or leaving.

Reasonably practicable

Proportionate: weighing what a step achieves against its cost, time and difficulty.

Immediate vicinity

The area close to the premises. There is no fixed distance.

SIA

The Security Industry Authority, the regulator for Martyn's Law.

Senior individual

The person an organisation must designate for enhanced tier premises.

Acknowledgement

A recipient's confirmation that an alert has been read and acted on.

Holding line

A short, accurate statement used while facts are still being established.

PLATFORM

Where Crises Control fits on the night

How the steps in this playbook map to Crises Control modules.

Send one lockdown or evacuation alert to every member of staff on duty by SMS, push and voice, and see who has replied.	**Ping** Mass alerting by push, SMS, voice and email, with acknowledgement tracking and escalation on no response.
Give door staff and duty managers a one-touch way to raise the alarm, with their location.	**SOS** One-touch mobile escalation with GPS location for frontline staff.
Turn the four procedures and each shift role into tasks with owners, so nothing depends on memory.	**Task Manager** Digitised procedures: tasks assigned with owners, deadlines and escalation paths.
Run the incident from one workspace with one log, shared by the site, the on-call manager and head office.	**Incident Manager** A workspace per incident: team coordination, a single communication log and message templates.
See which sites are affected, who has acknowledged and where escalations are waiting.	**Control Centre** A live view of tasks, communications, locations and escalations.
Keep a timestamped record of every alert and decision for the review, the insurer and the regulator.	**Audit Trail** Automatic timestamps and incident timelines, ready for the post-incident report.

SOURCES

Sources and notes

Accessed November 2026. Martyn's Law duties are not yet in force; check GOV.UK and the SIA for the commencement date.

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13 TechCrunch, report on IHG's 6 September 2022 stock exchange filing, 7 September 2022, https://techcrunch.com/2022/09/07/ihg-hotels-outage-cyberattack/

Every guest safe. Every shift ready.

Crises Control helps hotels, bars, restaurants and venues alert every member of staff in seconds, see who has replied, run the incident from one place and keep a full record for the regulator.

Request a demo crises-control.com

READ THE COMPANION REPORT

Intelligence report No. 05 · The protect duty